

20–10 BCE



In western Asia, the ruler of Galilee, **Herod I**, was allowed to retain his position by **Octavian**, even though he had supported Mark Antony. He was even **given extra territories**, including parts of Syria and Gaza. Herod had been appointed by Mark Antony in 42 BCE, and by 37 BCE he had conquered the remains of the **Hasmonean kingdom** (see 146–131 BCE). Herod remained a reliable **ally of Rome** until his death in 4 BCE.

#### Emperor Augustus

*Augustus, seen here dressed as a priest, acquired the title of pontifex maximus (chief priest) on the death of Lepidus in 12 BCE.*



“HE COULD JUSTLY BOAST THAT HE HAD FOUND IT BUILT OF BRICK AND LEFT IT IN MARBLE.”

**Suetonius**, on Augustus's embellishment of the city of Rome; from *Lives of the Caesars*

**AUGUSTUS'S MILITARY AND POLITICAL SUCCESSES** had relied largely on the abilities of **Marcus Vipsanius Agrippa**, who rose from a minor family to become consul in 37, 28, and 27 BCE. After Agrippa had married Augustus's daughter Julia, he received numerous promotions, including tribune of the plebs in 18 BCE. Augustus's own appointed heir had died in 25 BCE, so he **adopted Agrippa's children**, renaming them **Gaius** and **Lucius Caesar**. Agrippa seemed likely to succeed Augustus, but in 12 BCE he died unexpectedly, throwing open the **question of succession**.

By threatening to **invade Parthia** in 20 BCE, Augustus had engineered the return of legionary standards captured by the Parthians at **Carrhae** (see 53 BCE). In 16 BCE, the Roman governor of Macedonia began pushing toward the River Danube, and from 12 BCE **Tiberius**, Augustus's stepson, the son of his second wife Livia, moved north from Illyria to create the Roman province of **Pannonia** (modern Austria and Hungary). Tiberius's brother **Drusus** pushed Roman control across the Rhine toward the Elbe between 12 and 9 BCE,

when he died. Around this time, the Romans annexed the provinces of **Raetia** (in modern Switzerland) and **Noricum** (between the Alps and the Danube), **moving the empire's frontiers** almost to a line along the Rhine and the Danube. Supporters of Tiberius, now the most **high-profile general**, tried to have him displace Lucius and Gaius Caesar as Augustus's heir. Augustus himself did little to resolve the question of succession.

#### ROMAN LITERATURE AT THE TIME OF AUGUSTUS

The end of the Republic and the reign of Augustus saw a golden age in Latin literature. The orator Cicero and the historian Sallust marked the height of late Republican literature. After Augustus's rise to power, the poets Virgil (right; 70–19 BCE), author of the *Eclogues* and the epic poem *The Aeneid*, and Horace (65–8 BCE), author of the *Odes* and *Carmen Saeculare*, both flourished under the patronage of Maecenas, a close confidant of Augustus.

9–1 BCE

“THOSE WHO SLEW MY FATHER I DROVE INTO EXILE... AND... DEFEATED THEM IN BATTLE.”

**Augustus**, from the *Res Gestae Divi Augusti*, the testament of Augustus, in Ankara, Turkey

**BY 9 BCE, DRUSUS HAD DEFEATED THE MAIN GERMAN TRIBES** and had reached the Elbe River. After his death, Augustus appointed **Tiberius** to replace him. Tiberius won a series of victories in 8 BCE, but then mysteriously **resigned his offices** and went into exile in Rhodes. This left Gaius and Lucius Caesar (both underage) as **heirs apparent** to the Roman Empire.

In China, the **reign of Yuandi** (49–33 BCE) saw the economic retrenchment begun under **Xuandi** (see 70–61 BCE) continue. Some semi-independent kingdoms that the early Han had suppressed began to reappear. Yuandi and his successors **Chengdi** (r. 33–7 BCE) and **Aidi** (r. 7–1 BCE) also created numerous **marquisates**, many of which were granted to the sons of the new kings, weakening the state's central control. Chengdi lacked a **male heir**, resulting in



#### Khazneh at Petra

*The Khazneh is one of Petra's finest monuments. Carved out of a sheer cliff-face, it was probably a royal tomb, perhaps of Aretas IV (c. 9 BCE–40 CE).*

the succession of his half-nephew Aidi in 7 BCE. This caused **dissent** among nobles whose candidates for the throne had been overlooked.

The **Nabataean kingdom** of northern Arabia grew rich on its control of the spice trade from southern Arabia, reaching its height in the mid-1st century BCE under **Malichos I** (c. 59–c. 30 BCE). It then faced a growing threat on its northern borders from **Herod I**. A disputed succession in 9/8 BCE between **Aretas IV** and his chief minister **Syllaeus** led the Romans to take an interest in the area. An expedition led by Gaius, grandson of Augustus, may even have briefly annexed Nabataea in 3–1 BCE, but the Romans pulled back, allowing Nabataea another century of independence.

c. 25 BCE Buddhist canon written down for the first time in Sri Lanka  
23 BCE Romans invade the Merottic kingdom (modern Sudan)  
25 BCE Doors to the Temple of Janus in Rome are closed, signifying peace throughout the Roman world  
25 BCE Juba II made king of Mauretania by Augustus

19 BCE Herod I rebuilds the temple at Jerusalem  
20 BCE Rome and Parthia make peace; the Roman standards captured at the Battle of Carrhae are returned  
15 BCE Roman conquest of Raetia and Noricum  
18 BCE Agrippa, close associate of Augustus, made tribune of the plebs  
14 BCE Major peasant uprising in China  
12 BCE Death of Agrippa, likely successor to Augustus, opens up question of who will succeed Augustus  
12–9 BCE Roman conquest of Germany as far as the Elbe  
10 BCE Herod I completes building of seaport at Caesarea

9 BCE Roman campaigns against Maroboduus of the Marcomanni along the Danube  
9 BCE Drusus completes Rome's campaign against German tribes; he dies, leaving his brother Tiberius as leading contender to succeed Augustus as emperor  
8 BCE Tiberius goes into exile in Rhodes  
7 BCE In China, Emperor Chengdi is succeeded by Aidi, his half-nephew  
4 BCE Probable birth date of Jesus Christ  
4 BCE Augustus establishes the praetorian guard as imperial bodyguard  
4 BCE Herod I dies; his kingdom is divided between his three sons